Finding Partners

In December 2012, Snowden anonymously sent e-mails to journalist Glenn Greenwald. Snowden had become familiar with Greenwald after reading articles Greenwald had written about the wars in Iraq and Afghanistan and about government surveillance. When Greenwald failed to respond to his e-mails, Snowden e-mailed filmmaker Laura Poitras in January 2013. Snowden had seen some of the documentaries Poitras had made and knew she was currently filming a documentary on surveillance. He had also read a 2012 article Greenwald had written for *Salon* magazine about the problems Poitras was having at airports after the US government had flagged her as a possible terrorist. Based on her work and personal experiences, Snowden believed Poitras would understand the information he

COMPUTER ENCRYPTION

Encryption is a way to keep data on a computer safe, whether the data is stored on a computer's hard drive or sent over the Internet. Encryption software makes data unreadable by scrambling it into cipher text, a secret code that can be unlocked only with a personal key. Only the user and the person receiving the data know the key. Encryption can be effective. A randomly selected, 16-character key could take billions of years to decode.

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